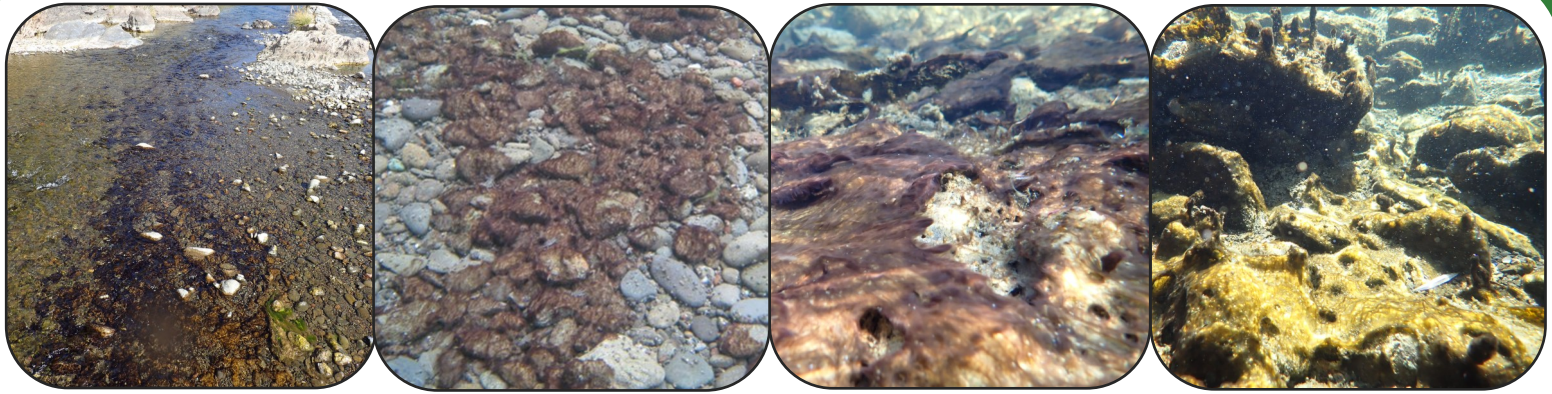
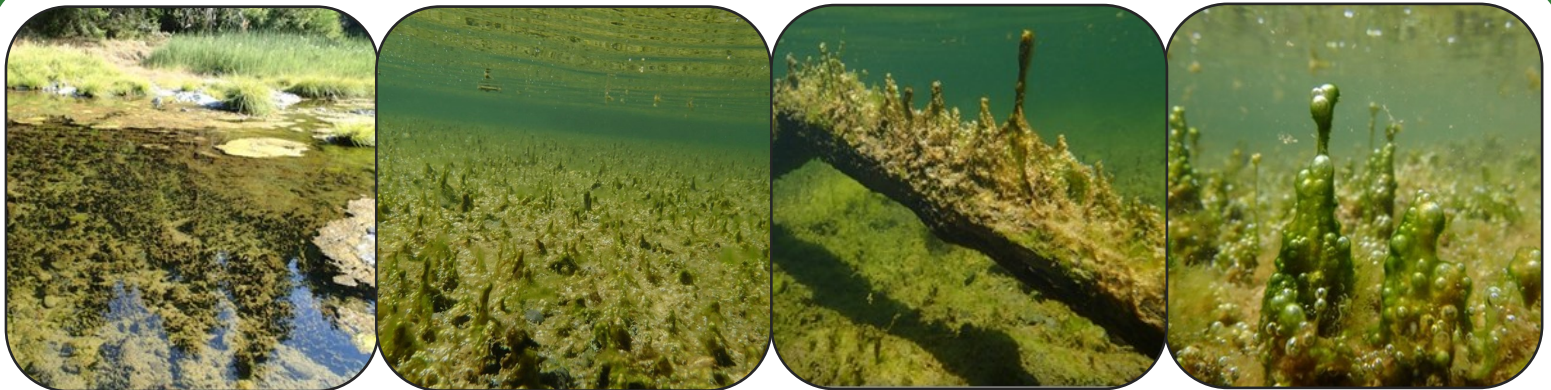


Factsheet for Identifying Benthic Cyanobacteria

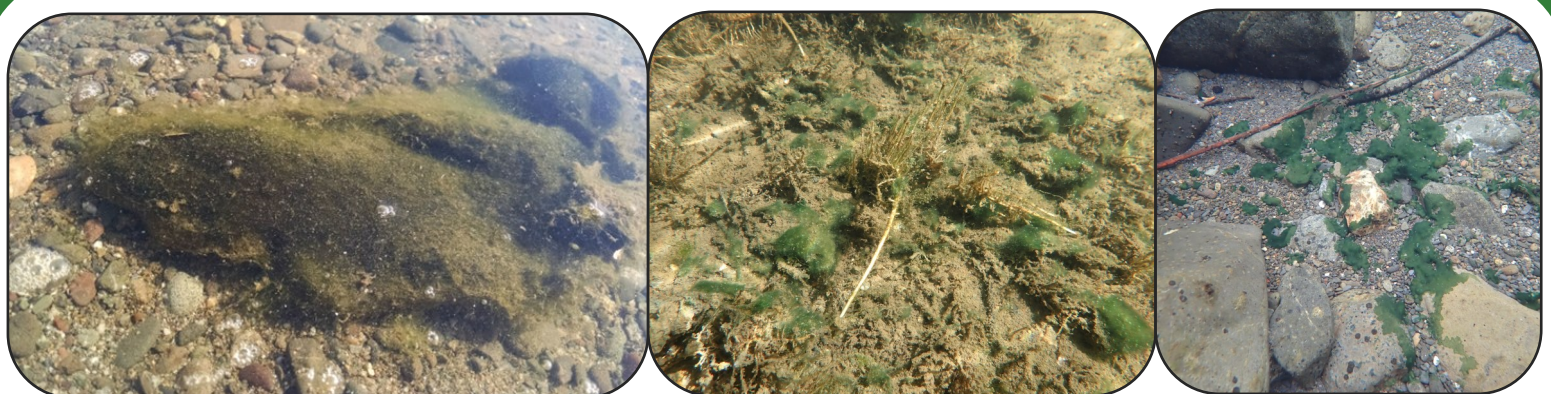
Benthic cyanobacteria, also known as blue-green algae or toxic algal mats, grow attached to the bottom of rivers and lakes. Similar to cyanobacteria that grow in the water column (planktonic), benthic harmful algal blooms (HABs) can produce toxins that are harmful to people and animals. Potential exposure increases when benthic cyanobacteria form mats that can detach from the bottom, float to the water surface, and accumulate in areas that are frequented by people and pets. This guide provides a visual comparison to help identify common benthic cyanobacteria and distinguish it from other non-toxic algae and aquatic plants.



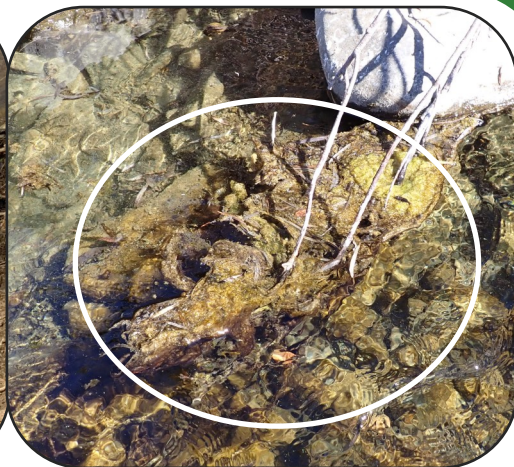
Dark brown mats: grow on cobbles and boulders; often in fast-moving water; mats have velvet-like appearance; easily dislodged when disturbed; begin to peel from rocks and turn golden brown as they age.



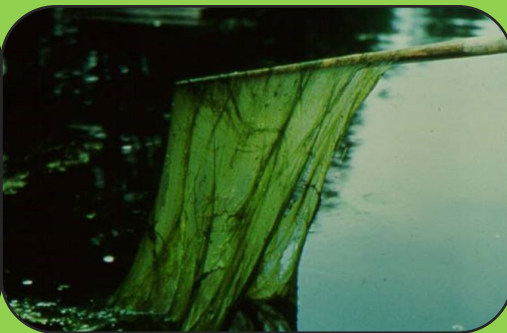
Forest green spires or bubble towers: grow in and among filamentous green algae; often in slow-moving water; create bubbles that allow mat to float when detached; usually darker green than non-toxic algae.



Other benthic cyanobacteria: mats can appear fuzzy, form thin green layers on other plants and debris, or create a fine film on small pebbles and sand; can be found in slow-moving water and shaded areas.

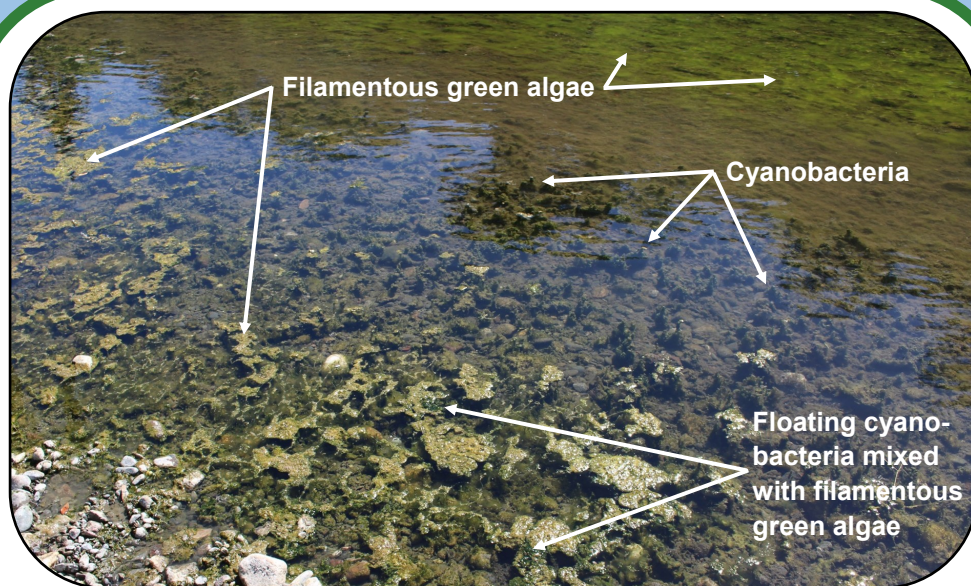


Floating benthic mats: once detached, benthic cyanobacterial mats (circled above) float downstream and become stranded on banks and beaches where they are easily accessible by children and pets.



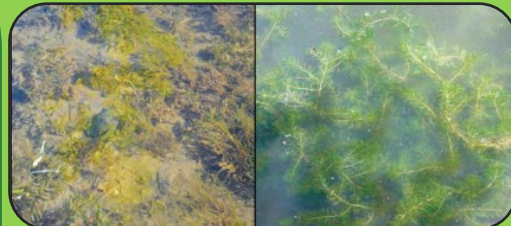
Filamentous Green Algae (non-toxic)

Unlike cyanobacteria, non-toxic green algae grow in long filaments that can be removed from the water like wet hair. Cyanobacterial mats fall apart when removed or smear when rubbed with a gloved hand.



Cyanobacteria vs. green algae: floating clumps or spires of cyanobacteria are darker green than the filamentous green algae.

Aquatic Plants (non-toxic)



Rooted plants: stem- and leaf-like structures underwater.



Floating plants: small green or red leaves with hanging roots.



◀ Scan here for a comprehensive visual guide.
For more information and to report suspected HABs, visit mywaterquality.ca.gov/habs



California
Freshwater and Estuarine
Harmful Algal Bloom
(FHAB) Program